



Swimming sequence
of a green turtle



Turtle shell is
streamlined for
gliding through
water

UNDERWATER FLIER

Green turtles live in warm waters in the Atlantic, Pacific, and Indian Oceans. Like all turtles, they come ashore to lay their eggs. First the females mate in shallow water with the waiting males. Later, under cover of darkness, the females crawl up the beach to lay their eggs in the sand before heading back to the water. They may return several times in one breeding season to lay further batches of eggs. Some green turtles are known to travel several hundred miles or more to reach their breeding beaches where they hatched themselves. Green turtles feed on sea grasses and seaweeds.



Front pair of
flippers help
turtle to "fly"
through water

Turtles are
air breathers,
so must come
to surface
to breathe
through their
nostrils

Green turtle
(*Chelonia mydas*)
is on the
endangered
species list

TURTLE TRIP

In the Japanese legend, Urashima Taro rides into the kingdom of the sea on a turtle. After spending some time in the depths, he begs the sea goddess to let him go home. She allows this, but gives him a box which he must never open.

On his return he finds his home has changed and no one knows him. Hoping for some comfort, he opens the box but the spell is broken. He becomes a very old man because he has spent not three years—but 300—in the sea.

